The sole local grain produced here is rice, claims Marco. People use only their right hand for eating, saving the left for sundry ‘unclean’ tasks. They drink fluids ‘out of flasks, each from his own; for no one would drink out of another’s flask’. Nor do they set the flask to their lips, preferring to ‘hold it above and pour the fluid into their mouths’. They are addicted to chewing a leaf called tambur, sometimes mixing it with ‘camphor and other spices and lime’. They go about spitting freely—also using it to express serious offense by targeting the spittle at another’s face, which can sometimes provoke violent clan fights.

They ‘pay more attention to augury than any other people in the world and are skilled in distinguishing good omens from bad’. They rely on the counsel of astrologers and have enchanters called Brahmins, who are ‘expert in incantations against all sorts of beasts and birds’. For instance, they protect the oyster divers ‘against predatory fish by means of incantations’ and for this service receive one in twenty pearls the divers extract from the sea. Each day, people refrain from doing business during a preordained unlucky hour that differs across days of the week.

People ‘worship the ox’ and do not eat beef—except the *gavi*, a group of people with low social status, who ‘eat cattle when they die a natural death’ and are not admitted inside holy places. Marco also records a custom among some people in which a dead man’s wife ‘flings herself into the same fire and lets herself be burnt with her husband. The ladies who do this are highly praised by all’. People daub their houses with cow dung. In battle they use lance and shield and, according to Marco, are ‘not men of any valor or spirit’ and ‘kill no beasts or any living thing. When they have a mind to eat the flesh of a sheep or of any beast or bird, they employ a Saracen [Muslim] or some other who is not of their religion or rule to kill it for them’. Most do not consume any alcohol, and do ‘not admit as a witness or a guarantor either a wine drinker or one who sails on the sea’. They say that ‘a man who goes to sea must be a man in despair’. Marco observes that people ‘do not regard any form of sexual indulgence as a sin’.

Their temple monasteries have both male and female deities, prone to being cross with each other, when they also ‘refrain from [sexual] intercourse’. The priests know when this happens, and since estranged deities spell nothing but trouble in the human realm, bevies of spinsters gather there several times each month with ‘tasty dishes of meat and other